War, Peace and Conscientious Objection

43 key historical facts stated in Jeff Kisling's blog posts on this topic, each checked against an outside source.

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These posts trace U.S. conscription and Quaker resistance to it, from Civilian Public Service in World War II through the Vietnam-era draft, lottery and draft-card resistance, the 1948 and 1968 Richmond statements, the 1980 return of registration, and the automatic registration enacted in 2025. They also cover the Korean War and diplomacy with North Korea, the atomic bombings, the post-9/11 wars and the 2001 AUMF, U.S. military budgets, drone warfare and the Russian invasion of Ukraine, often as background for the New Conscientious Objector and Active Objection ideas.

43 facts checked against outside sources. Each fact lists the source that confirms it and the posts that state it. The wording is a plain summary, not a quotation from the posts.

Facts

1. 1941–1947

Civilian Public Service (CPS) operated from 1941 to 1947 under the Selective Training and Service Act of 1940, assigning about 12,000 conscientious objectors to 'work of national importance under civilian direction' in camps run with the historic peace churches (Brethren, Friends and Mennonites).

- **Source:** Alternative Service: Conscientious Objectors and Civilian Public Service in World War II (The National WWII Museum); Civilian Public Service (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Draft Resister Stories (2017-04-29); Another Mentor, Another Quaker Jailbird (2019-10-22)

2. 1942-06-04

Congress has formally declared war 11 times; the last declaration came during World War II (against Romania, June 4, 1942). Later wars, including Korea, Vietnam, Iraq and Afghanistan, were fought under congressional authorizations or resolutions rather than declarations of war.

- **Source:** Declarations of War (U.S. Senate)

- **In the posts:** Lost Ideals (2017-04-08); Peace in a culture of violence? (2020-10-21); War, Peace and the Environment (2019-05-28)

3. 1944–1946

Civil rights and peace activist Bayard Rustin was imprisoned from 1944 to 1946, at the federal prisons in Ashland, Kentucky, and Lewisburg, Pennsylvania, for violating the Selective Service Act as a conscientious objector.

- **Source:** Bayard Rustin: The Inmate that the Prison Could Not Handle (National Archives (Rediscovering Black History blog))
- **In the posts:** John Griffith–War Resistance (2017-12-06); The Duty to Resist (2022-04-19)

4. 1945-08-06

The United States dropped atomic bombs on Hiroshima on August 6, 1945, and on Nagasaki on August 9, 1945, the only uses of nuclear weapons in war.

- **Source:** Atomic Bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki (National Archives (The Unwritten Record blog))
- **In the posts:** Remember Hiroshima and Nagasaki (2018-08-02); Remember Hiroshima (2018-08-06); Remembrance of the Victims of the Bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki (2018-08-09)

5. 1948-07

A national gathering of Friends at Earlham College in Richmond, Indiana, adopted the 'Advices on Conscription and War' on July 20–22, 1948, urging Friends not to unite with any Selective Service draft, approving civil disobedience under divine compulsion, and supporting those who opposed conscription by non-registration or by registering as conscientious objectors.

- **Source:** Advices on Conscription and War (Richmond, Indiana, 1948) (Inward Light)
- **In the posts:** Peacemaking: fill the spiritual void (2022-11-08); International Day of Peace (2023-09-21); Richmond Declaration on the Draft (2019-10-05)

6. 1950-06-25

The Korean War began on June 25, 1950. Fighting stopped with the Armistice Agreement of July 27, 1953, but no peace treaty has ever been signed, so the war has never formally ended.

- **Source:** Armistice Agreement for the Restoration of the South Korean State (1953) (National Archives)
- **In the posts:** Follow-up on North Korea (2022-06-22); Support Peace on the Korean Peninsula (2018-05-16); Korean War Memorial (2023-11-27)

7. 1954-06-01

Congress renamed Armistice Day as Veterans Day in 1954; President Eisenhower signed the change into law that year (the renaming took effect June 1, 1954).

- **Source:** From Armistice to Veterans Day (National Archives (Prologue blog))
- **In the posts:** Honoring all victims of war, including those who resisted (2022-11-19)

8. 1959-09-23

Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev visited Iowa on September 23–24, 1959, touring Roswell Garst's farm near Coon Rapids and Iowa State University, an episode later cited as a model of citizen and agricultural diplomacy.

- **Source:** Soviet Leader Nikita Khrushchev Visits Iowa Farm (Teaching Iowa History (State Historical Society of Iowa))
- **In the posts:** Swords into plowshares (2017-10-07); Bear Creek Friends Meeting and North Korea (2017-10-09); US-Korea Exchanges Possible (2017-10-10)

9. 1964-08-07

Congress passed the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution on August 7, 1964, after reported attacks on U.S. destroyers, authorizing President Lyndon Johnson to 'take all necessary measures to repel any armed attack'; later investigations found the second reported attack (August 4) likely never happened. The resolution was the legal basis for escalating the Vietnam War and was repealed in January 1971.

- **Source:** Tonkin Gulf Resolution (1964) (National Archives)
- **In the posts:** Stop the March to War (2019-05-09); Questions and observations (2022-03-11); Is Trump Yet Another U.S. President Provoking a War? (2019-05-18)

10. 1965-07

A July 1965 Selective Service orientation memo titled 'Channeling' described using deferments as 'pressurized guidance' to steer young men into occupations the government considered to be in the national interest.

- **Source:** Channeling (Selective Service System, July 1965) (Edward Hasbrouck)
- **In the posts:** Scattergood Journal – Beginning to plan next Moratorium Day (2017-11-10)

11. 1965-08

In August 1965 Congress passed, and President Johnson signed, a law making it a federal crime to destroy or mutilate a draft card, punishable by up to five years in prison and a $10,000 fine.

- **Source:** Meet the First Vietnam War Protestor to Be Prosecuted for Burning His Draft Card (TIME); Old Gold: Steve Smith, following his conscience (University of Iowa (Iowa Now))
- **In the posts:** Honoring all victims of war, including those who resisted (2022-11-19)

12. 1965-10-15

David J. Miller burned his draft card at an antiwar rally in New York City on October 15, 1965, becoming the first person prosecuted under the new draft-card law; five days later, on October 20, 1965, University of Iowa student Steve Smith burned his card at the Iowa Memorial Union, the first to do so on a college campus after the law took effect.

- **Source:** Meet the First Vietnam War Protestor to Be Prosecuted for Burning His Draft Card (TIME); Old Gold: Steve Smith, following his conscience (University of Iowa (Iowa Now))
- **In the posts:** Honoring all victims of war, including those who resisted (2022-11-19)

13. 1967-04-04

Martin Luther King Jr. delivered his speech 'Beyond Vietnam: A Time to Break Silence' at Riverside Church in New York City on April 4, 1967, exactly one year before his assassination.

- **Source:** Beyond Vietnam (Martin Luther King, Jr. Research and Education Institute, Stanford University)
- **In the posts:** When silence is not an option (2017-04-05); Martin Luther King, “Beyond Vietnam: A Time to Break Silence” (2021-04-08); 20 Years of Endless War: Special Silent Reflection (2021-09-06); Martin Luther King Jr was a radical (2022-04-05); Beyond Vietnam (2025-01-16)

14. 1967-04-28

Muhammad Ali refused induction into the U.S. Army in Houston on April 28, 1967, was convicted of violating Selective Service law that June, and had the conviction unanimously reversed by the U.S. Supreme Court in Clay v. United States on June 28, 1971.

- **Source:** Clay v. United States (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Muhammad Ali and me (2016-06-04); Muhammad Ali and me (2020-09-11); Memorial Day 2017 – Vietnam War (2017-05-29)

15. 1968-10-11

The Friends National Conference on the Draft and Conscription, convened by the Friends Coordinating Committee on Peace at Earlham College in Richmond, Indiana, on October 11–13, 1968, issued the Richmond 'Declaration on the Draft and Conscription'. It reaffirmed the 1948 Advices, rejected draft reform ('the issue is

not equal treatment under compulsion, but freedom from compulsion'), and urged resistance such as refusing to register and refusing war taxes.

- **Source:** 1968 Richmond Declaration re Draft (Inward Light); Declaration on the Draft and Conscription (Illinois Yearly Meeting)
- **In the posts:** Richmond Declaration on the Draft (2019-10-05); National Quaker Conference on the Draft 1968 (2026-02-07); International Day of Peace (2023-09-21)

16. 1969-10-15

The first nationwide Moratorium to End the War in Vietnam took place on October 15, 1969, with demonstrations and teach-ins across the United States; a second Moratorium followed on November 15, 1969.

- **Source:** Moratorium to End the War in Vietnam (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Connections (2017-11-08); Intersection of Inner and Outer Light (2018-01-28); Fifty Years Ago (2019-10-17); Protest and Protect (2019-10-29)

17. 1969-12-01

The first Vietnam-era draft lottery was held on December 1, 1969, at Selective Service headquarters in Washington, D.C.; birth dates drawn at random set the order of induction, replacing the earlier 'oldest first' method.

- **Source:** Vietnam Lotteries (Selective Service System)
- **In the posts:** Looking Back (2019-08-18); The Supreme Court (2020-09-19); No Way Out but War (2022-05-24)

18. 1970-05-04

On May 4, 1970, Ohio National Guard soldiers fired on antiwar protesters at Kent State University, killing four students and wounding nine.

- **Source:** 50 years ago, the Kent State shootings sparked student unrest across America (National Geographic)
- **In the posts:** Another time of cultural chaos (2020-04-21); Kent State Massacre (2025-05-06)

19. 1973-06-30

The last U.S. draft call was issued on December 7, 1972, and the authority to induct men expired on June 30, 1973, after which the military relied on an all-volunteer force.

- **Source:** Vietnam Lotteries (Selective Service System)

- **In the posts:** Military Recruitment, Schools, Free Speech and Peace (2020-09-02); No Way Out but War (2022-05-24); Peace in a culture of violence? (2020-10-21)

20. 1980

The American Friends Service Committee (AFSC) has engaged with North Korea since 1980, when it sent the first delegation by a U.S. humanitarian organization to the North since the Korean War; from 1997 it ran an agricultural program with North Korean cooperative farms and scientists.

- **Source:** A Quaker legacy of working for peace in Korea (American Friends Service Committee)
- **In the posts:** AFSC's work in North Korea (2018-03-21); Rising tensions with North Korea and farm diplomacy (2022-06-16)

21. 1980-07

Draft registration was suspended on April 1, 1975, and resumed in July 1980 for men born in 1960 and later; the registration requirement for young men has remained in effect since.

- **Source:** Vietnam Lotteries (Selective Service System)
- **In the posts:** Draft resistance and conscientious objection (2018-05-25); Another Mentor, Another Quaker Jailbird (2019-10-22); Vietnam War 50 years later (2025-04-30)

22. 2001

In 2001 Ro Song Cho, then deputy director of North Korea's agriculture ministry, visited Bear Creek Friends Meeting in Iowa during a seven-week U.S. tour; AFSC had begun bringing North Korean agricultural scientists to the U.S. in 1999.

> ***Note:*** *The NK News account does not explicitly name AFSC as host of the 2001 visit.*

- **Source:** Sowing the seeds of improving agriculture: Quakers in North Korea (NK News); A Quaker legacy of working for peace in Korea (American Friends Service Committee)
- **In the posts:** Bear Creek Friends Meeting and North Korea (2017-10-09); Swords into plowshares (2017-10-07)

23. 2001-09-18

The Authorization for Use of Military Force (Public Law 107-40), allowing the President to use force against those responsible for the September 11 attacks and those who harbored them, was approved on September 18, 2001, and has since been used as the legal basis for a wide range of military operations.

- **Source:** Public Law 107-40: Authorization for Use of Military Force (Congress.gov)
- **In the posts:** Authorization for War (2017-07-06); House Repeal of AUMF and Friends Committee on National Legislation (FCNL) Advocacy (2019-05-22)

24. 2003-03-20

The U.S.-led invasion of Iraq began on March 20, 2003, justified largely by claims of Iraqi weapons of mass destruction; no WMD stockpiles were found, and U.S. forces completed their withdrawal on December 18, 2011.

- **Source:** Iraq War (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Is Trump Yet Another U.S. President Provoking a War? (2019-05-18); Rumours of War (2016-06-24); Temporary Memorial for the Children of Gaza (2025-03-10)

25. 2004

AFSC's 'Eyes Wide Open' exhibit, first shown in Chicago in 2004, displayed a pair of military boots for each U.S. service member killed in the Iraq war, with shoes representing Iraqi civilian dead; it later traveled to 48 states and the District of Columbia.

- **Source:** American Friends Service Committee (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Temporary Memorial for the Children of Gaza (2025-03-10); Efforts to call attention to Gaza (2025-04-11)

26. 2015-07-14

The Iran nuclear agreement (Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action) was reached on July 14, 2015; President Trump withdrew the United States from it on May 8, 2018, and reimposed sanctions.

- **Source:** What was in the Iran nuclear deal and why did Trump withdraw the US from it? (ABC7 News (Associated Press))
- **In the posts:** Why the Iran Deal Succeeded (2015-10-06); Remember Hiroshima and Nagasaki (2018-08-02); Dangerous Escalation (2020-01-06)

27. 2016-05-27

On May 27, 2016, Barack Obama became the first sitting U.S. president to visit Hiroshima, where he called for a world without nuclear weapons.

- **Source:** Obama Becomes 1st Sitting U.S. President to Visit Hiroshima (NBC News)
- **In the posts:** President Obama visits Hiroshima (2016-05-28)

28. 2017-02-27

On February 27, 2017, the Trump administration announced a budget plan raising defense spending by $54 billion, about 10 percent, offset by cuts to foreign aid, the State Department and domestic agencies.

- **Source:** Why does President Trump want to add $54 billion to the defense budget? (Christian Science Monitor)
- **In the posts:** Republican Military Budget (2017-03-13)

29. 2017-06-29

The House Appropriations Committee adopted Rep. Barbara Lee's amendment to repeal (sunset) the 2001 AUMF on June 29, 2017, and adopted a similar Lee amendment again on May 21, 2019; neither became law.

- **Source:** FCNL Applauds Passage of Amendment to Repeal 2001 AUMF (Friends Committee on National Legislation); Key House committee approves curbing Trump's war authorization powers (CBS News); One Small Step for the House, One Giant Leap for Peace (Friends Committee on National Legislation)
- **In the posts:** Authorization for War (2017-07-06); House Repeal of AUMF and Friends Committee on National Legislation (FCNL) Advocacy (2019-05-22); War, Peace and the Environment (2019-05-28)

30. 2018

The Department of Defense reported about 1.3 million active-duty military members (1,304,418) in 2018.

- **Source:** 2018 Demographics: Profile of the Military Community (Military OneSource (U.S. Department of Defense))
- **In the posts:** Military Recruitment, Schools, Free Speech and Peace (2020-09-02)

31. 2018-01-09

On January 9, 2018, after talks with South Korea, North Korea agreed to send athletes and a delegation to the PyeongChang Winter Olympics in South Korea.

- **Source:** North Korea to send team to Winter Games, South to consider easing bans after talks (The World (PRX/Reuters))
- **In the posts:** North Korea and the Olympics (2018-01-09); Introduction to AFSC in North Korea (2018-03-09)

32. 2018-04-27

At their April 27, 2018 summit at Panmunjom, the leaders of North and South Korea signed a declaration stating that 'a new era of peace has begun' and committing to pursue talks aimed at formally declaring an end to the

Korean War.

- **Source:** Full text: Panmunjom Agreement on Korea launches 'new era of peace' (UPI)
- **In the posts:** “A new era of peace” in Korea (2018-04-27)

33. 2018-06-12

At the Singapore summit on June 12, 2018, President Trump and North Korean leader Kim Jong Un signed a joint statement that included a commitment to recover POW/MIA remains from the Korean War, including immediate repatriation of those already identified.

- **Source:** Trump and Kim have signed a 4-point peace pledge at their summit. Here's what it says (World Economic Forum)
- **In the posts:** Singapore Summit (2018-06-12)

34. 2018-11-14

Brown University's Costs of War project estimated in November 2018 that U.S. post-9/11 wars had cost $5.9 trillion spent and obligated through fiscal year 2019, including future veterans' care.

- **Source:** $5.9 Trillion Spent and Obligated on Post-9/11 Wars (Watson Institute, Brown University)
- **In the posts:** House Repeal of AUMF and Friends Committee on National Legislation (FCNL) Advocacy (2019-05-22); COP 26 and Beyond Coal and Gas Alliance (2021-11-14)

35. 2020-01-03

Iranian general Qasem Soleimani was killed by a U.S. MQ-9 Reaper drone strike at Baghdad International Airport on January 3, 2020.

- **Source:** CI879: January 3, 2020 (Airwars)
- **In the posts:** Dangerous Escalation (2020-01-06); A moment of reckoning (2021-01-09); Militarism and LANDBACK (2021-09-05)

36. 2020-02

The President's national defense budget request for fiscal year 2021 totaled $740.5 billion, including $705.4 billion for the Department of Defense.

- **Source:** DoD Releases Fiscal Year 2021 Budget Proposal (U.S. Department of Defense, Comptroller)
- **In the posts:** COVID-19, SHIFT and FCNL (2020-04-16)

37. 2020-03-25

The congressionally created National Commission on Military, National, and Public Service issued its final report on March 25, 2020, recommending among other things that Selective Service registration be expanded to include women.

- **Source:** National Commission Final Report (Selective Service System)
- **In the posts:** Draft resistance and conscientious objection (2018-05-25); National Commission on Military, National, and Public Service (2018-06-25)

38. 2021-08-30

The Taliban took Kabul on August 15, 2021, as the Afghan government collapsed, and the last U.S. troops left Afghanistan on August 30, 2021, ending nearly 20 years of U.S. war there.

- **Source:** Withdrawal of United States troops from Afghanistan (2020–2021) (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Militarism and LANDBACK (2021-09-05); 20 Years of Endless War: Special Silent Reflection (2021-09-06)

39. 2021-12

In 2021 both the Senate and House Armed Services Committees approved provisions in the defense authorization bill requiring women to register for Selective Service, but the provision was dropped from the final compromise bill in December 2021.

- **Source:** Congress Drops Effort to Add Women to the Draft (Military.com)
- **In the posts:** Militarism and LANDBACK (2021-09-05)

40. 2022-02-24

Russia launched its full-scale invasion of Ukraine on February 24, 2022; that day Ukraine ordered a general mobilization and barred men aged 18 to 60 from leaving the country.

- **Source:** Russian invasion of Ukraine (Wikipedia)
- **In the posts:** Conscientious objection and Ukraine (2022-03-18); Split Screen (2022-03-03); Fog of War (2022-03-07)

41. 2022-12

The fiscal year 2023 National Defense Authorization Act, passed by the House on December 8, 2022, authorized $858 billion for national defense, $45 billion above the administration's request.

- **Source:** House Passes FY 2023 NDAA That Authorizes $858B for National Defense (USNI News)
- **In the posts:** FCNL: Reduce the Pentagon Budget (2023-02-19)

42. 2025-12

The fiscal year 2026 National Defense Authorization Act, signed into law in December 2025, requires the Selective Service System to register draft-eligible young men automatically using federal data instead of relying on self-registration; automatic registration is scheduled to begin after December 18, 2026, and does not include women.

> ***Note:*** *Sources checked confirm the law, the December 2025 enactment and the December 2026 start, but did not name the section number (the post says Section 535) and describe the covered ages as 18 to 26 (the post says 18–25).*

- **Source:** Automatic Draft Registration: Not Just a Bad Idea, It's the Law (Quaker House); Automatic military draft registration takes effect in December. Here's how it would work (ABC11)
- **In the posts:** The draft and youth today (2026-09-01)

43. Undated

U.S. military records held by the National Archives list 58,220 American military fatal casualties of the Vietnam War.

- **Source:** Vietnam War U.S. Military Fatal Casualty Statistics (National Archives)
- **In the posts:** No Way Out but War (2022-05-24); War is never the answer (2022-10-19); My Journal and Leadings for Young Friends Today (2026-08-29)

Not yet verified

These statements appear in the posts but could not be checked against an outside source during this pass. They are not confirmed and not shown to be wrong.

- Over 3,300 civilians have been killed by U.S. drone strikes in Pakistan. In the posts: Rumours of War
- From 2001 to 2017, about 42,100 Taliban and other militants, 31,419 Afghan civilians, 30,470 Afghan military and police, 3,946 humanitarian workers and 2,371 U.S. troops were killed in the war in Afghanistan. In the posts: Should the United States leave Afghanistan?
- A U.S. Supreme Court ruling on men whose lottery numbers came up during a pause in inductions meant some Vietnam-era draft resisters, including the author, were not prosecuted. In the posts: The Supreme Court; Vietnam War 50 years later
- Section 535 of the FY2026 NDAA amends the Military Selective Service Act to require automatic registration of males aged 18–25. In the posts: The draft and youth today